

CHESS MASTERY LIBRARY | FIRST EDITION

Endgame Foundations

King activity, pawn races, and precise conversion

THE PROMISE

Master the small set of ideas that organize a large share of practical endings.

VOLUME 11 OF 15

READ | RECALL | DECIDE | RETEST

What this volume should change

- Use the king as a fighting piece when mating danger has receded.
- Calculate pawn races with key squares, opposition, and the rule of the square.
- Convert advantages by restricting counterplay before collecting pawns.

HOW TO STUDY

Read one section. Close the PDF and state its decision rule from memory. Solve the position lab before viewing the answer. Revisit the lab after two days and again after one week.

Inside this volume

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This volume is an original teaching synthesis of established chess ideas. Positions marked illustrative are designed to isolate a decision, not to replace full-game analysis. Board diagrams use Colin M. L. Burnett's Cburnett piece artwork from Lichess, licensed GPLv2+.

The king changes role

With fewer pieces, the king becomes an active attacker, blocker, and escort. Centralization often matters more than saving a distant pawn. The correct moment depends on checks: a king can be active only when enemy forcing moves are controlled.

Position cues

- Approach passed pawns from the front when possible.
- Use the king to attack two pawns or defend two weaknesses.
- Cut off the opposing king before taking material.
- When queens remain, calculate checks before centralizing.

PRACTICE RULE

In every endgame, compare king routes in moves, not impressions. A one-tempo difference often decides the result.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Do not rush to win a pawn if the capture allows the enemy king to enter your position.

Key squares and promotion support

A pawn's key squares are king destinations that guarantee promotion against a lone king, assuming normal conditions. For a pawn before the fifth rank, the key squares lie two ranks ahead; once the pawn reaches the fifth rank, nearby sixth-rank squares become decisive.

Position cues

- Put the king in front of the pawn when possible.
- Gain access to a key square before pushing automatically.
- A rook pawn has special drawing resources because the board edge reduces routes.
- Check whether the defending king can take opposition.

PRACTICE RULE

Practice king-and-pawn positions from both sides until you can predict the result before moving pieces.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Memorizing 'king in front' without counting tempi can fail when the pawn is too advanced or the defender has opposition.

Opposition and corresponding squares

Opposition is a fight over entry squares between kings. Direct opposition is the simplest case: kings face each other with one square between. The player who must move often yields access. More complex endings use corresponding squares: when one king occupies a square, the other must answer with its paired square.

Position cues

- Direct opposition: same file or rank, one square between.
- Distant opposition: odd number of squares between, used to approach.
- Diagonal opposition: a route for transferring direct opposition.
- Reserve tempo: a pawn move that changes whose turn it is.

PRACTICE RULE

Do not chant 'take opposition.' Identify the entry square you are trying to gain or deny.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Opposition is a means, not the objective. Sometimes stepping aside reaches a key square while direct opposition draws.

The rule of the square and pawn races

The rule of the square quickly tests whether a king can catch an unsupported pawn. Imagine a square extending from the pawn to its promotion rank. If the king can enter the square on its move, it can usually catch the pawn. Captures, checks, and king obstruction can modify the result.

Position cues

- Count double-step availability from the starting rank.
- In mutual races, calculate promotion with check and queen captures.
- A king may block the opposing king while escorting its pawn.
- Connected passers can protect one another and change the square.

PRACTICE RULE

First use the square as a filter, then calculate the exact race including the final promotion tempo.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Do not stop at 'both queen.' The first promotion may give check, capture the other pawn, or force a queen trade.

Zugzwang and triangulation

Zugzwang occurs when the obligation to move worsens the position. Triangulation is a king maneuver that reaches the same position with the other side to move. Pawn reserve tempi can serve the same purpose.

Position cues

- List legal waiting moves for each side.
- Identify the position you want with the opponent to move.
- Count whether your king can lose one tempo by a triangular route.
- Preserve pawn moves that may function as reserve tempi.

PRACTICE RULE

In quiet king endings, compare not only destinations but parity: who moves when the critical position appears?

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Do not spend pawn tempi casually. A harmless push can remove the only waiting move that saves the ending.

A conversion ladder

Winning an endgame is usually a sequence: stop counterplay, improve the king, create or fix a second weakness, force favorable exchanges, and only then collect material. The order protects against pawn races and tactical resources.

Position cues

- Restrict enemy activity and passed pawns.
- Improve the king and worst piece.
- Create a second target or outside passed pawn.
- Trade into a known winning mechanism.
- Recalculate at every pawn move and exchange.

PRACTICE RULE

Before grabbing a pawn, state the opponent's most active reply. If it creates a race or entry, improve first.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

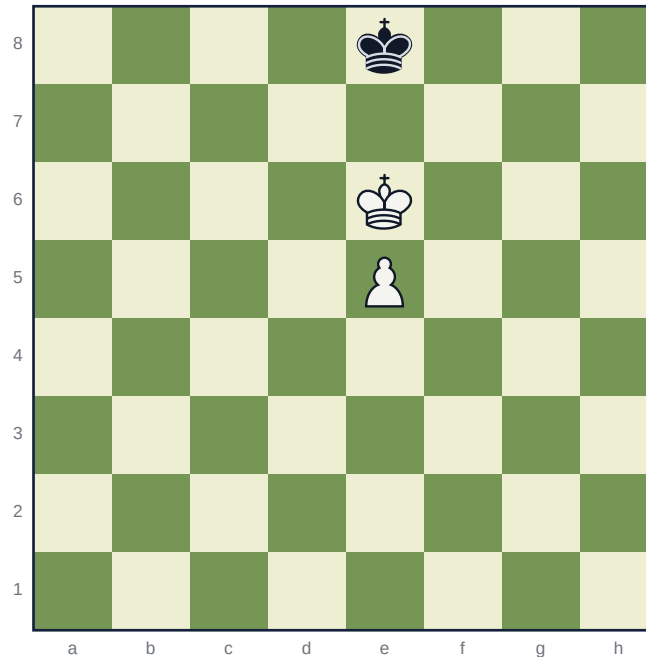
A material advantage is not self-converting. Activity and outside passers can outweigh one pawn.

Position Lab

Do not turn the page until you have written a candidate list or explanation. Score the process separately from whether your final answer is correct.

LAB 01

White has reached a key-square type position. Explain why the king's placement matters more than pushing immediately.



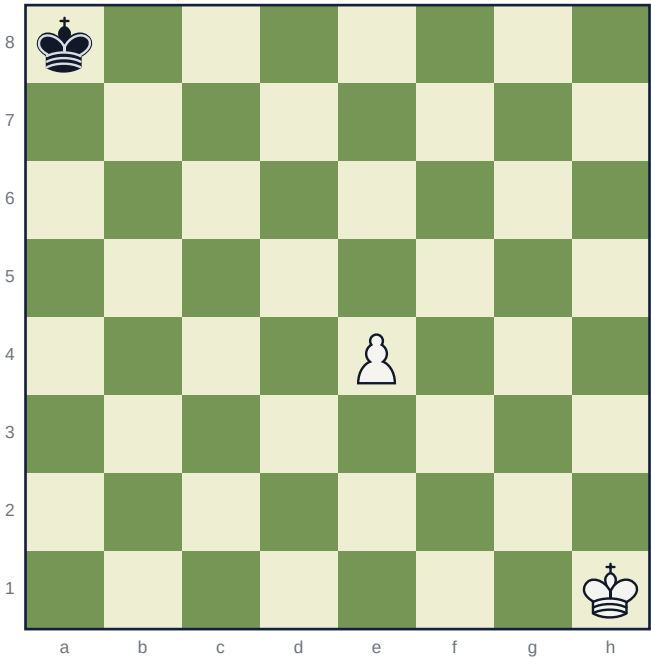
King in front of a passed pawn

BEFORE CHECKING

Name the cue, list at least two candidates or explanations, and test the strongest objection.

LAB 02

Black to move. Use the rule of the square as a first test: can the black king catch the e-pawn?



Rule-of-the-square filter

BEFORE CHECKING

Name the cue, list at least two candidates or explanations, and test the strongest objection.

Position Lab - Answers

LAB 01

The king on e6 controls the squares in front of the e-pawn and can support promotion. The key idea is to preserve king access and use opposition as needed. Pushing without checking king geometry can surrender the decisive entry square.

LAB 02

Yes. From e4 the pawn's promotion square is e8, and the catch square extends to a8. The black king is already on the boundary and moves first, so it can enter the route and catch the unsupported pawn. Verify exact tempi after using the geometric shortcut.

Daily Study Card

Use this as a compact recall sheet. Say each item without looking, then open the volume only for the item you cannot explain.

- Activate the king only after checking enemy checks.
- Count routes and tempi exactly.
- Gain key squares before pushing automatically.
- Preserve reserve pawn moves.
- Stop counterplay before collecting material.

TRANSFER TEST

During your next five serious games, mark every position where this volume's cue appeared. Improvement means you noticed the cue and used a better process, even when the game result was noisy.

CONTINUE WITH

02_Rook_and_Piece_Endgames.pdf

Personal notes